

| By Nirmala Ravindran |

The last few decades have seen a surge in the Indian art industry. Breaking free from the shackles of the 'cottage industry' tag, impressive sales figures have helped the art market in its runaway growth. With over a hundred A-list galleries in the metros alone, not to speak of smaller towns with their share of local artists catering to the local market, it is surprising that India has only produced a handful of professional curators. On his recent visit to India, Dr Robert Storr, Dean of the Yale School of Art, had emphasised the importance and need to develop a school for curators. "Curating is not just about putting a show together, it is a professional and powerful voice. In India, I see the growth in sales and the impressive price tags, but where are the curators?" asks the former curator in the Painting and Sculpture section of the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA).

This is a big year for India; first, because it occupies a place of pride at several important art destinations



Artist as CURATOR

Artists doubling up as curators raise the question of specialisation and its relevance to the Indian art scene



across the world, and second, because it marks the coming of age of artist Krishnamachari Bose as a curator of international repute. Having curated the Indian Pavilion at ARCO, Madrid, in February, Bose is on to his next big achievement—a show within a show, curated by him at the Astrup Fearnley Museum of Modern Art in Oslo, Norway. Opened in the first week of April, 'The Indian Highway' will be on till August. One of the biggest art

shows of its kind, it will travel across the world before reaching India in 2012. Bose is following the steps of artists like Vivan Sundaram who created path-breaking shows like 'Seven Sculptors' in the 1980s.

It is the lacunae in the curatorial process in India that have seen several artists turn curators in the recent past. While Bose remains the most feted both in India and abroad, others like Chintan Upadhyaya and Subodh

Gupta have created a storm in the art industry with their ventures. "It's wonderful that artists are turning curators because they understand aesthetics better," says leading art historian and independent curator Alka Pande who rues the fact that India has not created enough space for the growth of independent curators. "Where is the space in India to showcase independent curatorial works? We neither have a Metropolitan Museum nor a